



Easter Island Moai

Monumental ancestral statues created by the Rapa Nui people and unique to Easter Island in the Pacific

At some time in the first millennium, a group of Polynesians settled on the remote island of Rapa Nui, 2,300 miles (3,700 km) off the coast of Chile. Between the 11th and 17th centuries, the Rapa Nui people carved 800–1,000 colossal stone figures, each believed to embody the spirit of a prominent ancestor. Often erected on ceremonial platforms known as *ahus*, the statues (*moai*) face inland, watching over the island and its people. Most were carved from blocks of yellow-brown volcanic tuff and have an oversized head. Some also feature a red tuff *pukao*, or top-knot, and are thought to be among the later statues carved.

Walking statues

The question of how the *moai* were transported large distances from the quarry where they were carved has long been disputed. Theories about

rolling tree sledges have now given way to the theory that the statues were harnessed with ropes and “walked” across the island by being tilted and pulled from side to side.

European colonists arrived on Rapa Nui in 1722. By the late 18th century, most of the *moai* had been toppled. The process of reerecting the statues began in 1978, and UNESCO declared Easter Island a World Heritage Site in 1995. In 2018, the islanders asked the British Museum in London to return a statue taken from the island in 1868.

▷ ALL-SEEING EYES

The only statue to have had its eyes restored is at *Ahu Ko Te Riku*. The *moai* had deep eye sockets, where pieces of white coral were placed during rituals.

